

The Keeper of Small Lights

A Novel

MARGUERITE VALE

HARBOUR & SON

Chapter One

The Green Ledger

The lighthouse keeper had counted the ships for thirty-one years, and in all that time he had never once seen the harbour empty. There was always something out there, a hull or a mast or the small red eye of a running light, moving against the grey. He wrote the numbers in a ledger bound in green cloth, and when the ledger was full he began another, and the years stacked up on the shelf above the stove like cordwood. The lighthouse keeper had counted the ships for thirty-one years, and in all that time he had never once seen the harbour empty. There was always something out there, a hull or a mast or the small red eye of a running light, moving against the grey. He wrote the numbers in a ledger bound in green cloth, and when the ledger was full he began another, and the years stacked up on the shelf above the stove like cordwood.

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A Note on the Instruments

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- the brass sextant, unused since the war
- a barometer with a cracked face
- three lamps and a tin of wicks

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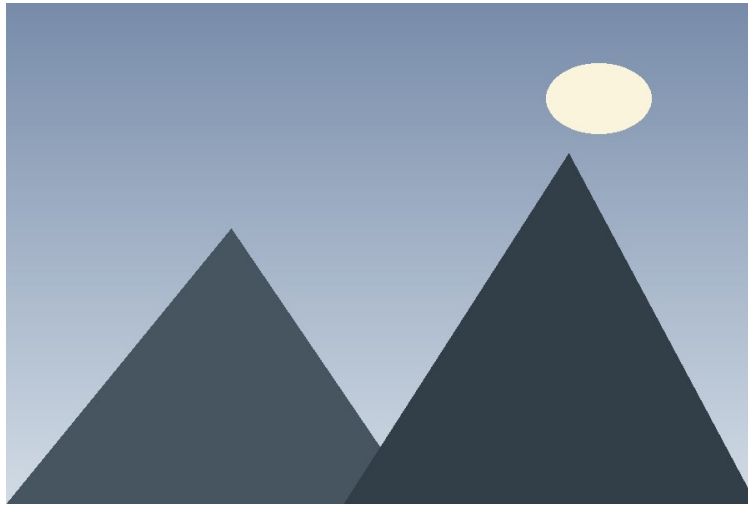


Figure 1. The north light, seen from the breakwater.

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Chapter Two

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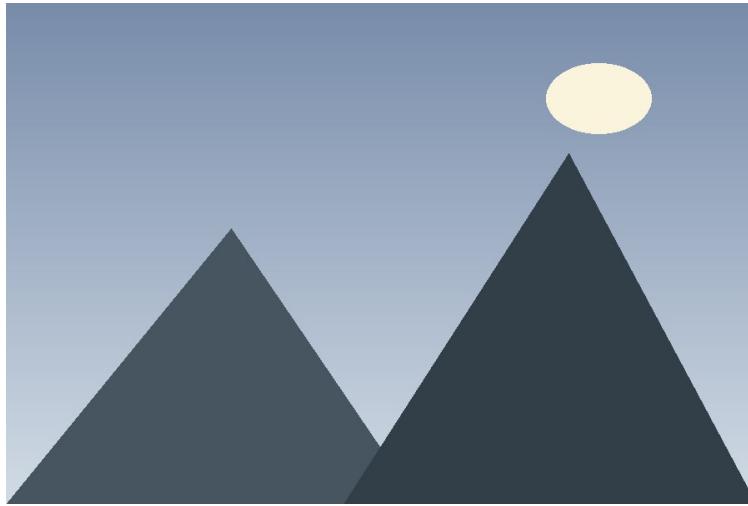


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Chapter Three

The Bell Buoy

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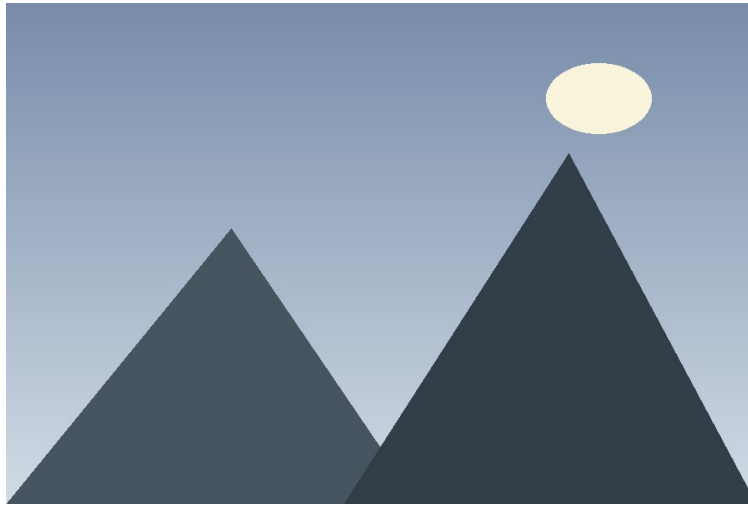


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